

WATERFOWL

Species in this group are web-footed birds adapted for surface swimming. The majority feed on plants, although some take small aquatic animals.

Most waterfowl have short legs set well back on the body. These birds, the Anseriformes, swim by propelling themselves with webbed feet, and all have plumage kept waterproofed with oil taken from a gland near the tail. South American screamers and the magpie-goose from Australasia have partially webbed feet, spending much of their time on land or wading in marshes. These birds belong to two ancient families. All other waterfowl are classified in a single family, the most primitive group being the whistling ducks.

SWANS, GEESE, AND DUCKS

In swans and geese, the sexes have similar plumage patterns. These long-necked, long-winged birds occur mostly outside the tropics. Many northern species breed close to the Arctic and migrate southwards to overwinter. Ducks are generally smaller and have a shorter neck than others in the Anatidae family.

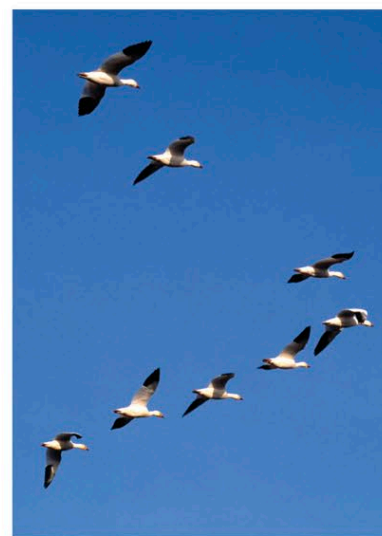
Unlike geese and swans, male ducks are usually more brightly plumaged than the females, especially when breeding. Both sexes of many duck species have a vividly coloured wing-patch called a speculum.

The typical “duckbills” of waterfowl have internal plates that have evolved to strain aquatic food drawn in by a muscular tongue. All species retain this feature, even though some have adopted different feeding methods. Geese graze on grasslands, but swans are more aquatic and use their long neck to plunge their head deep in water. Many ducks dabble – up-ending to feed on or just below the water surface. Others, such as pochards, dive under water to gather food. The saw-billed ducks have a narrow bill with serrated edges to catch fish. One group of ducks, including eiders, scoters, and mergansers, includes accomplished sea divers.

NESTING

Most waterfowl are monogamous, some pairing for life. They nest largely on the ground, but a few nest in trees. The marine ducks come inland to breed. All waterfowl produce downy chicks that can walk and swim soon after hatching.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	ANSERIFORMES
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	177



Flying in formation reduces air drag, enabling birds like these snow geese to conserve energy on long migrations.



53–56 cm
21–22 in

RED-BREASTED GOOSE
Branta ruficollis
F: Anatidae

This is the most brightly coloured member of the *Branta* group of dark geese. It breeds in northwestern Siberia, where it nests close to raptors, possibly for protection from foxes.

striking red, black, and white plumage



50–110 cm
20–43 in

CANADA GOOSE
Branta canadensis
F: Anatidae

The largest of the *Branta* geese, this species is native to N. America, but has been introduced to northern Europe.



58–71 cm
23–28 in

BARNACLE GOOSE
Branta leucopsis
F: Anatidae

This goose breeds on Arctic tundra in Greenland and Russia, where it avoids predators by nesting on cliff tops.



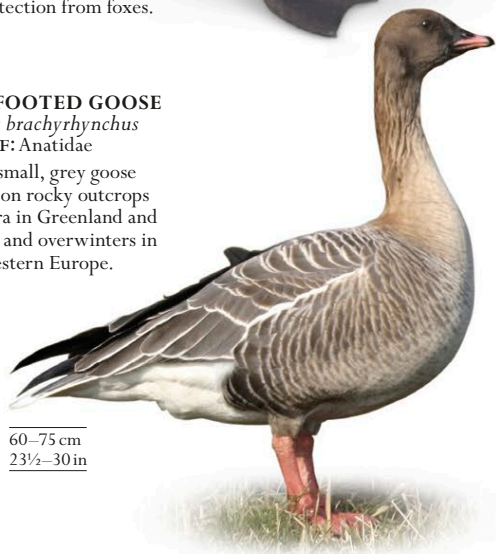
56–71 cm
22–28 in

HAWAIIAN GOOSE
Branta sandvicensis
F: Anatidae

Confined to the Hawaiian Islands, this goose has reduced foot-webbing and strong claws, and is adapted to climbing on to rocky lava flows.

PINK-FOOTED GOOSE
Anser brachyrhynchus
F: Anatidae

This small, grey goose breeds on rocky outcrops of tundra in Greenland and Iceland, and overwinters in western Europe.



60–75 cm
23½–30 in

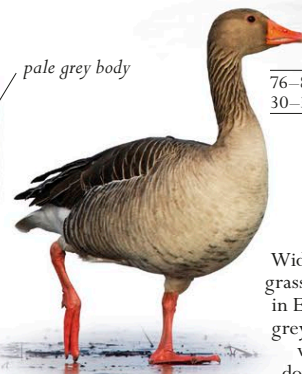


BAR-HEADED GOOSE
Anser indicus
F: Anatidae

This bird is adapted to the thin air of montane C. Asia. Migrating high over the Himalayas, it overwinters in India and Myanmar.

71–76 cm
28–30 in

pale grey body



76–89 cm
30–35 in

GREYLAG GOOSE
Anser anser
F: Anatidae

Widespread across the grasslands and wetlands in Eurasia, this typical grey *Anser* goose is the wild ancestor of domesticated geese.